

Your first prenatal visit

Your first prenatal appointment usually takes place between 8 and 12 weeks. At this visit, your prenatal records will be started and you will have a chance to discuss any concerns or issues with your doctor.

At your initial visit, you will meet the doctor who will be providing your care. She will ask you questions about your past and present health and about medical conditions in your family. You will also have a physical examination and blood and urine tests. Your due date will be estimated based on the date of your [last menstrual period](#).

Medical history

The doctor will take a full medical history to check for health problems, and identify your pregnancy as high or low risk. If there is a problem, she will explain how this could affect your pregnancy. If you have an existing condition, she'll discuss how your pregnancy may affect your health and if your treatment needs to change. Inform the doctor of any medications you're taking; certain ones, such as some of those for high blood pressure, may need to be changed (see [Illnesses and medications](#)).

You will be asked about drug use and sexually transmitted diseases. It's important to be honest so that your doctor can identify and prevent potential problems. You may also be asked about your previous obstetric history, including any previous miscarriages or terminations of pregnancy. If your partner is unaware of a past event and you feel sensitive about this, tell your doctor privately and ask for it to remain confidential.

Family history

The doctor will ask about any health problems in your own and your partner's family. This is important because some conditions can be passed on, and testing may be available to identify whether your baby is affected.

Height and weight

A baseline height and weight measurement will be taken to calculate your body mass index (BMI; see p.16). A BMI of more than 30 puts you in a higher risk group for complications. Losing weight in pregnancy is not recommended, but your doctor will give you advice about healthy eating and exercise to avoid excessive weight gain.